PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS

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MEMO

Date: **January 20, 2026**

To: Board of Education

CC: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent
Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff

From: Ben Gurewitz, Senior Manager, Government Relations

Subject: 2026 Legislative Priorities

BACKGROUND

The Legislature will convene for the 2026 Short Session from February 2nd to March 8th. The short session's compressed timeline means limited runway for policy development, rapid committee deadlines, and clear prioritization. The legislature will primarily focus on the budget deficit, protecting immigrants, and raising revenue.

KEY DATES

January 13-15: Legislative Days
January 16: Deadline to Introduce Legislative Measures
February 2: 2026 Session Begins
February 4: Quarterly Revenue Forecast
February 9: Post Work Session Deadline
February 16: 1st Chamber Deadline for Work Sessions
February 17: COSA, OSBA, OAESD, OASBO Joint Advocacy Day
February 20: Post Work Session Deadline
February 26: 2nd Chamber Deadline
March 9: Adjournment

2026 Legislative Session Preview

Top of mind for everyone will be how the state wrestles with the existing budget deficit during the current biennium. Oregon faces an estimated $600 million budget gap—driven largely by the impacts of HR 1—and the outlook for the 2027–29 and 2029–31 biennial grows more challenging as those impacts compound. In the September 2025 revenue forecast the State Economist projected a $373 million budget hole for the 2025-27 biennium. In response, Governor Kotek asked state agencies to prepare budget reduction options in 2.5% and 5%

increments. An updated revenue forecast in November found that the deficit shrunk from $373 million to roughly $63.1 million.

The Legislature will receive an updated Revenue Forecast on February 4th. This forecast will include updated unemployment data unavailable last fall because of the government shutdown.

Heading into the 2026 legislative session, we recommend that the team focus on key three priorities: preventing cuts to education, raising additional revenue to narrow the budget deficit and protect our community members who are being impacted by ICE.

Key Bills to be tracked

During the Short Session, each legislator is allowed to introduce no more than 2 bills, and each committee can introduce up to three bills. Below is a list of bills we will be tracking:

- A bill that would make class size, student and teacher safety, and discipline mandatory subjects of bargaining. This bill is Sponsored by the House Committee on Labor and Workplace Development
- A bill sponsored by Senator Neron Misslin (D-Wilsonville) which would require that every school offer free meals to every student. This program would be funded by an existing program in the federal government.
- There are two bills that would require that schools and universities to notify parents if federal immigration agents appear on campus. One version of the bill is sponsored by Senator Lew Fredrick (D-Portland), the other is sponsored by Representative Sara Finger-McDonald (D-Corvallis).
- A bill to codify the federal McKinney-Vento Act which would guarantee students experiencing homelessness the right to enrollment, transportation and access to learning. This bill is sponsored by Representative Emerson Levy (D-Bend)
- A bill that would retroactively fund outdoor school in Oregon. This bill is sponsored by Representative Hudson (D-Troutdale).
- Representative Lamar Wise (D-SE Portland) has a bill that would require quarterly reporting on attendance data to the Department of Education.
- Education Committee bills

Legislative Engagement and Advocacy

PPS will be participating in the Joint Advocacy Day with our colleagues, from COSA, OSBA, OAESD, and OASBPO. This will be an opportunity to meet directly with legislators about our legislative agenda with a primary focus on protecting K-13 budgets from reductions or cuts. The 2026 Advocacy Day is Tuesday, February 17th from 8:00 am to 5:00. Please contact Ben Gurewitz, Senior Manager of Government Relations at bgurewitz@pps.net if you would like to attend or have a specific legislator you would like to meet with.